Physical and Sexual Development in Adolescence

What is adolescence?

Adolescence is the period of transition between childhood and adulthood. It begins with puberty 9-12 years for girls and 11 -14 for boys) and ends at adulthood (about age 21). Children entering adolescence are going through many changes. These include physical, intellectual, psychological and social changes, as well as development of their own moral compass. The changes are rapid and often take place at different rates. It can be an exciting yet challenging time in the life of a teenager. Adolescence is the time when the individual becomes more independent and begins to explore their identity.

What are the physical changes of adolescence?

Physical development in adolescence includes changes that occur through a process called puberty. During puberty, a child's brain releases certain hormones. The hormones stimulate physical changes including the maturation of sexual organs.

Most children experience a growth spurt. There is a rapid increase in height and weight. Other physical changes may include body odor, acne and an increase in body hair. Growth spurts usually happen earlier for girls than for boys. Most girls have growth spurts between the ages of 10 and 14, while boys have growth spurts between the ages of 14 and 17.

Girls will begin to develop breasts. This can happen as young as age 10 and should start by age 14. They'll also experience their first period (menarche) — usually about two years after breasts and pubic hair are first noticeable.

Boys will see their penis and testicles grow. They'll begin to experience erections and nocturnal ejaculations. (commonly referred to as wet dreams)

These physical changes happen to everyone, but the timing and order can vary from person to person. Some adolescents mature early, while others mature later. Being on either end of this spectrum can cause the added stress of standing out amongst their peers.

Impact of Early Maturation on Boys and Girls

Early maturing girls often find themselves confused as they suddenly realise that they start to look different from their age mates. This physical maturation often comes with pressure to change their behaviour and to act “more grown up”. They may also attract unwanted attention from older boys and may feel pressured to “become sexual” even though their brain is still not yet mature enough to accurately process sexual feelings. They are forced to learn to accept their rapidly changing bodies.

Early maturing boys tend to fare a little better than their female counterparts because they are bigger and stronger than their age mates. This allows them to perform better athletically and makes them more popular with girls as well as older boys. These factors afford them an elevated social status. There are also disadvantages to early maturation in boys, they are easy targets for peer pressure from older boys and they are often expected to “act their size” even though their young brains have not yet caught up to their rapidly maturing bodies

Body Image in Adolescence

Adolescence is a critical developmental period marked by significant physical, psychological, and social changes. Spanning roughly from ages 10 to 19, it is a period of profound transformation. Puberty brings about rapid physical changes, including alterations in height, weight, and body composition. These changes, coupled with heightened social awareness and increased exposure to media ideals, make adolescents particularly vulnerable to body image concerns. This section examines the factors influencing body image, including media exposure, peer influence, and family dynamics. It discusses the potential consequences of negative body image, such as eating disorders, depression, and low self-esteem. Furthermore, it outlines strategies teachers can employ to promote positive body image and foster healthy attitudes towards appearance among adolescents.

Body image, defined as an individual's perception, thoughts, and feelings about their physical appearance, plays a crucial role in shaping self-esteem, social interactions, and overall well-being during this formative time.

Factors Influencing Body Image in Adolescence

Several factors contribute to the development of body image during adolescence:

Media Influence

The media, including television, magazines, social media, and the internet, bombards adolescents with images of idealized bodies, often portraying unrealistic and unattainable standards of beauty. These images can lead to social comparison, where adolescents evaluate their own appearance against these idealized representations, often resulting in feelings of inadequacy and dissatisfaction. The pervasive nature of digitally altered images further exacerbates this issue, creating a distorted perception of reality and contributing to body image concerns.

Peer Influence

Peers play a significant role in shaping adolescents' attitudes towards appearance. Social acceptance and belonging are paramount during this stage, and adolescents often conform to peer norms and expectations regarding body size and shape. Teasing, bullying, and social exclusion based on appearance can have a devastating impact on body image and self-esteem. Conversely, supportive and accepting peer relationships can foster positive body image and resilience.

Family Dynamics

Family dynamics also influence body image development. Parental attitudes towards appearance, weight, and dieting can significantly impact adolescents' perceptions of their own bodies. Critical comments about weight or appearance, pressure to conform to certain body ideals, and modeling of unhealthy eating behaviors can contribute to negative body image. Conversely, supportive and accepting family environments that emphasize health and well-being over appearance can promote positive body image.

Psychological Factors

Underlying psychological factors, such as self-esteem, perfectionism, and anxiety, can also contribute to body image concerns. Adolescents with low self-esteem may be more vulnerable to negative body image, as they may rely on external validation to feel good about themselves. Perfectionistic tendencies can lead to excessive self-criticism and dissatisfaction with appearance.

Anxiety, particularly social anxiety, can exacerbate body image concerns, as adolescents may worry excessively about how they are perceived by others.

Consequences of Negative Body Image

Negative body image can have a range of detrimental consequences for adolescents' physical and mental health:

Eating Disorders

Body dissatisfaction is a major risk factor for the development of eating disorders, such as anorexia nervosa, bulimia nervosa, and binge-eating disorder. Adolescents with negative body image may engage in extreme dieting, excessive exercise, or other unhealthy behaviors in an attempt to achieve an idealized body shape.

Depression and Anxiety

Negative body image is strongly associated with depression and anxiety. Feelings of shame, guilt, and inadequacy related to appearance can contribute to low mood, hopelessness, and social withdrawal.

Low Self-Esteem

Body image is closely linked to self-esteem, and negative body image can significantly undermine self-worth and confidence. Adolescents with negative body image may feel less capable, less attractive, and less worthy of love and acceptance.

Social Isolation

Body image concerns can lead to social isolation, as adolescents may avoid social situations or activities where they feel self-conscious about their appearance. This can further exacerbate feelings of loneliness and depression.

Risky Behaviors

In some cases, adolescents with negative body image may engage in risky behaviors, such as substance abuse or self-harm, as a way to cope with their distress and attempt to compensate for their feelings of inadequacy..

Promoting Positive Body Image

Promoting positive body image among adolescents is crucial for their overall well-being. Strategies for fostering healthy attitudes towards appearance include:

Media Literacy Education

Educating adolescents about media literacy can help them critically evaluate media images and understand the unrealistic and often unattainable standards of beauty portrayed. Encouraging them to question the messages they receive from the media and to recognize the use of digital manipulation can help reduce the impact of media influence on body image.

Promoting Body Positivity

Encouraging adolescents to embrace body positivity, which emphasizes acceptance and appreciation of all body types, can help challenge societal norms and promote self-acceptance. This involves focusing on the functionality and health of the body rather than solely on its appearance.

Fostering Self-Esteem

Building self-esteem through activities that promote competence, achievement, and positive social relationships can help adolescents develop a stronger sense of self-worth that is not solely dependent on appearance.

Encouraging Healthy Behaviors

Promoting healthy eating habits, regular physical activity, and adequate sleep can help adolescents feel good about their bodies and improve their overall well-being. Emphasizing the importance of health and well-being over weight or appearance can help shift the focus away from body image concerns.

Creating Supportive Environments

Creating supportive and accepting environments at home, school, and in the community can help adolescents feel valued and accepted for who they are, regardless of their appearance. This involves promoting positive communication, discouraging teasing and bullying, and celebrating diversity.

Seeking Professional Help

If an adolescent is struggling with significant body image concerns or is exhibiting signs of an eating disorder, seeking professional help from a therapist, counselor, or registered dietitian is essential. Early intervention can help prevent the development of more serious problems.

What are the cognitive changes in adolescence?

Brain development in adolescence is on a higher level than that of childhood. Children are only able to think logically about the concrete — the here and now. Adolescents move beyond these limits and can think in terms of what might be true, rather than just what they see as true. They can deal with abstractions, test hypotheses and see infinite possibilities. Yet adolescents still often display egocentric (childish) behaviors and attitudes.

During cognitive development in adolescence, large numbers of neurons grow rapidly. The body experiences an increase in the way these bundles of nerves connect. This allows for more complex, sophisticated thinking. The front part of the brain — the frontal cortex — is one of the last parts of their brain to fully develop. It doesn't finish maturing until the mid- to late 20s. This area of the brain controls executive functions such as planning, prioritizing and controlling impulses. Because it develops so late, teenagers may have lapses in judgment. There is an increase in risk-taking behaviors and mood swings. This is compounded by the action of hormones which alter mood and stimulate feelings of reward. Adolescents tend to gravitate to behaviours which bring them the quickest rewards. Often, these behaviours do not have the best long-term consequences.

When a teen isn't using their frontal cortex and is acting impulsively, this thought process is called hot cognition. Cold cognition refers to using the logical part of the brain. Parents and teachers can help redirect a young person from "hot" to "cold" cognition by responding with empathy, asking questions (rather than lecturing) and holding them to high expectations.

Mental characteristics that develop during adolescence include improved:

Abstract thinking.

Reasoning skills.

Impulse control.

Creativity.

Problem-solving abilities.

Decision-making skills.

Emotional changes in adolescence

Adolescents will begin to observe, measure and manage their emotions. That means they'll begin to become more aware of their own feelings and the feelings of others. The process of emotional development provides opportunities to build their skills and discover their unique qualities. As they become more independent, some adolescents welcome these new challenges. Others may need more support to build their self-confidence.

Development of self-esteem in adolescence?

The physical, hormonal and emotional changes your child experiences during adolescence may affect their self-esteem. Teenagers who develop early or late compared to their peers may be self-conscious of their bodies. Fitting in becomes ever more important to their self-esteem. Self-esteem can be complex. Some adolescents may have high self-esteem around their families but low self-esteem around their peers.

Instead of having a "helicopter parent" who swoops in and saves the day, or a "snowplow parent" who moves all challenges out of the way, adolescents benefit most from parents and parent figures who adopt a "lighthouse" approach. This kind of adult keeps the adolescent in bounds in matters of safety or ethics, while allowing them to explore their own decision-making abilities. The role of caring adults who serve as a lighthouse can be life-changing for teens.

It is important that adolescents learn to accept who they are and gain a sense of capability. They can develop their self-esteem by making mistakes, learning from their mistakes and learning to hold themselves accountable for their actions.

Social changes in adolescence

Adolescents are also developing socially during this time. The most important task of social development in adolescence is the search for identity. This is often a lifelong voyage that launches during adolescence. Along with the search for identity comes the struggle for independence. They may:

Develop an interest in their sexuality and romantic relationships.

Turn to parents and other adults less in the midst of a challenge.

Assert greater independence

Spend less time with parents and more time with their friends.

Feel anxious, sad or depressed, which can lead to trouble at school or risk-taking behaviors.

Development of identity

Identity development occurs when the adolescent discovers a strong sense of self and personality, along with a connection to others. Positive self-identity is important because it shapes perception of belonging throughout life. A positive self-identity is also associated with higher self-esteem. You can help reinforce a positive self-identity in teens by:

Encouraging their efforts.

Praising their good choices.

Inspiring perseverance.

Social media and adolescent development

Social media can negatively impact an adolescent's health and development. Adolescents report cyberbullying and exposure to inappropriate content online. In addition, socializing online isn't

the same as socializing in person. Adolescents miss out on key facial expressions and body language that they only see when they connect with a person face to face. Adolescents may also feel bad about themselves when comparing themselves to others they see online (social comparison). All of these factors can lead to lower self-esteem, depression and anxiety.

Moral changes in adolescence?

Adolescents learn to think about the world in a deeper, more abstract way. This helps shape how they how they want to interact with it. They also begin to develop morals and values that they hold throughout their life. They realise that not every decision is black or white. They'll develop empathy when they begin to see why people make choices that differ from their own. They also begin to have a deeper understanding of why there are rules in the world. They start to form their own opinions on what's right and what's wrong. They may also spend time thinking about their religious beliefs and spirituality. Conversations about these matters should be encouraged with adolescents. Adults should practice the art of listening and learning as teens practice thinking through issues and situations.